If you don't have chili-flavored olive oil, stir a little bit of piquant pimenton, harissa, or smoked paprika into fruity olive oil and drizzle over the servings.

mexican sweet corn soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

3 tbsp olive oil
1 Spanish onion, finely chopped
1 red bell pepper, halved, cored, seeded and finely chopped
1 clove garlic, crushed
1 tsp fennel seeds
1 tsp fresh thyme leaves
14oz (400g) sweet corn kernels (drained and rinsed, if canned)
salt and pepper
½ cup half-and-half
1½ tbsp chili-flavored olive oil, to serve

1 Heat the oil in a large sauté pan over medium heat, add the onion, bell pepper (reserve a scant tablespoon to finish), garlic, fennel seeds, and thyme, and stir-fry for 3 minutes. Add the sweet corn and season lightly. Continue stirring and cooking for 2 minutes, then pour in 2 cups hot water, stir, and bring to a simmer. Lower the heat, cover, and simmer for 15 minutes or until the vegetables are tender and cooked through. Stir in the half-and-half and let cool for a few minutes.

2 Process the soup until smooth in a blender (you may need to do this in batches). Return to the pan and reheat gently, stirring occasionally. Taste and adjust the seasoning. Ladle into bowls and add the reserved red pepper. Drizzle a little chili-flavored olive oil over the top and serve at once.



SWEET CORN
A seasonal delight. Look for locally grown cobs with the squeaky, stiff leaves that are a sign of freshness. The grains should be firm and bright yellow, not wrinkled. Use as soon as possible, as the corn will quickly lose its sweetness.